

Living Together and Your Benefits

Who the new cohabitation rule affects, who it does not, and what to do. A plain-language guide.

Through all the transition talk, there has been almost nothing clear about couples and people who live together. The fear is real, and a lot of it is people worrying about a cut that may not even apply to them. Here is the plain version. Find your situation below.

Three situations. Read the one that is yours.

1. You are a couple, and you both receive AISH or ADAP.

This is who the new cohabitation rule is for. Starting the August benefit period, which is the payment that lands at the end of July, each partner in a couple where both are on disability drops to 88 percent of the individual amount. That is about 12 percent less, each, every month.

In real dollars: a couple where both stay on AISH loses about 466 dollars a month, together. If you are moving to ADAP, this 88 percent cut lands on top of the ADAP base cut, so the total loss compared to your AISH today can reach about 817 dollars a month. All of this is before the 200 dollar federal benefit clawback on each of you. The full math, on the government's own numbers, is in our Income Crossover Analysis.

What to do: watch your end of July payment, and ask them, in writing, to show you exactly how they calculated it.

2. One of you is turning 65, or already has.

This one is the quiet trap almost nobody is talking about, and it can hit harder than the couples rule. When one partner turns 65, they leave AISH or ADAP for seniors' benefits: Old Age Security, the Guaranteed Income Supplement, and CPP. That seniors' income then gets counted against the other partner's AISH or ADAP.

Here is the painful part. Even when the partner who turned 65 now receives more than they did on AISH, the other partner's benefit can drop so much that the household ends up worse off overall than when you were both on AISH. Once one of you is on seniors' benefits, the 88 percent couples rule no longer applies to you. This is a different calculation.

There is some relief built in. A spousal pension exemption shelters the first 1,200 dollars of a partner's pension income, plus 25 percent of the rest. It softens the hit, but it may not undo it.

What to do: this is the one to watch most closely. Ask them, in writing, to show you exactly how they calculated your reduced benefit, and how they applied the spousal pension exemption. If they will not show you the math after you ask, write down that they would not. That refusal is part of the record, and it matters.

3. You live with a roommate, or a relative who is not your partner.

Good news: the cohabitation rule does not apply to you.

It is a couples rule. It is for spouses and partners. A roommate is not your partner. A sibling, an adult child, or a parent you share a home with is not your partner either. Under Alberta's Adult Interdependent Relationships Act, a relative can only be counted as your partner if the two of you have signed a formal partnership agreement, which almost nobody has. Simply living together does not make you partners.

So if you share a home with family or a roommate and you are not a couple, you each keep your full individual amount. If anyone tells you the cut applies to you because you live with someone, that is not correct. Come check with us first.

For everyone, no matter which situation is yours

Get every calculation in writing. If a payment changes and you cannot see why, do not just accept it. You have a right to know how your own benefit was worked out. Ask them to show you the math, and if they will not, write down that they refused, with the date. And if you are not sure which situation is yours, come ask us. That is what we are here for.

Verified against the AISH policy manual (updated July 2, 2026), the AISH General Regulation (AR 96/2026, Section 8(4)), the Government of Alberta ADAP fact sheet (May 12, 2026), and the Adult Interdependent Relationships Act. The manual confirms the couples reduction and the spousal pension exemption. Figures can change, so confirm the details that affect you by phone or in writing.

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